

How to buy an LCD

LCDs are the latest in display technology. With their sleek looks, and crisp displays, they are becoming a viable alternative. They use liquid crystal filled grids, activated by electric fields to create even, smooth, finely defined images. They are especially useful for places where desk space is in short supply. Here are a few things to look at before buying one.

Digital or Analogue Inputs: If you want a sharper display, you can look for a flat panel monitor with a digital input—also called Digital Video Interface (DVI). Remember that you will need a special graphics card with a DVI output connector.

Resolutions: Make sure that the native res-

olution of an LCD monitor matches what you normally use. Also look for monitors that offer the one-touch auto adjust feature that matches your screen display with your computer resolution.

Dead Pixels: One thing to look for in LCD monitors are dead pixels. These are pixels that are always on or always off. The simplest way to test for this is to display a totally white screen and look for black or coloured dots, and then display a totally black screen and look for white or coloured dots. A few dead pixels here and there won't really make a difference, but too many in the wrong place can become an irritation, and mar the display quality that you bought the LCD for.



monitor. It should have had a manual containing instructions on troubleshooting and maintenance of the LCD monitor, which would have helped this monitor gain some more points. Overall, it was a good competitor, but could have had some additional features—considering Rs 24,000 that you shell out to purchase it.

CMV, a lesser-known brand and a new player in the market, has monitors that provide a high luminance of around 400 cd/m², which drastically boost the brightness and contrast levels for vivid and lively pictures.

Lastly, the sleek looking Sony SDM S51, doesn't support wall mounting or height adjustment. Neither does it have DVI support, which is expected from a monitor priced at Rs 31,000. The maximum resolution supported by this monitor is 1024 x 768 at 60 Hz, which is below par, compared to other 15-inch LCD monitors. The accessories provided include the driver CD and a user guide. This monitor is suitable for home and office use, but the hefty price that you have to pay for this is not justifiable.

17-inch monitors

Built on similar lines as its sibling in the 15-inch category, the Samsung Sync Master 171 MP offers the same set of features and extends the elegant design aura to this monitor. The overall looks are enhanced by the metallic silver colour, with sleek styling and practical design. The 171 MP boasts of some impressive features, such as HDTV and an optional TV tuning capability. A full, function remote control provided along with it, makes your entertainment hours even more enjoyable. It has feather touch buttons on the front panel that beep when you press them to configure the OSD. The in-built speakers, envelope you with virtual surround sound. Its PiP feature allows you to watch TV and work on your computer simultaneously—the most impres-

the crowd. The design is gorgeous, the OSD is displayed in translucent blue and the control buttons beep when pressed. It has four buttons on the left side of the front panel to control the PC, Picture-in-Picture (PiP), Video and Audio settings. There is also an auto adjustment button to automatically set the properties to default values. To make the TV viewing even more enjoyable, a remote control is provided. It has in-built speakers that can provide virtual surround sound for a sweet and enjoyable experience. The only thing this monitor lacks is the support for DVI input—though it does have support for RCA and S-Video. To complete its 'home theatre' applications, the LCD can be wall mounted. It comes bundled with the mandatory user's manual, driver and colour calibrating software.

Built on similar lines as the Samsung's 151 MP, the Philips 150 MT 20P LCD monitor is dressed for the future. The features include support for HDTV, an external TV tuner, built-in speakers and a remote control. It has blue LED buttons

for accessing the translucent blue OSD menu. The buttons are feather touch and a joy to operate. It also has an auto button to automatically adjust screen settings. One notable feature is the high luminance of 310 (cd/m²). It supports RCA and S-Video, and comes with the necessary audio and video cables to connect it to a PC or DVD player. An interactive multimedia CD is provided, which doubles as the users guide and the driver CD.

LG's 566 LE has 5 buttons on the front panel, to help you navigate about the OSD. This is a sleek metallic looking monitor, with a sharp display—second in its category in the sharpness and resolution tests. The OSD takes a little getting used to. The monitor itself comes in a plain vanilla package, and includes only the user manual and a CD containing the drivers. We expected at least one colour profiling software to be included with the monitor, as LCD's are still considered to be premium products in India. The manual is also not exhaustive and contains only basic instructions for installing the



LG 566LE

- + Good performance
- No in-built speakers and low on features



Philips 150 MT20P

- + External T.V. tuner card; good luminance
- Low in performance



Philips 150 P4 AB

- + Compact design; height adjustable
- Expensive



Samsung Syncmaster 151MP

- + Good performance; HDTV ready
- Expensive



Samsung Syncmaster 152S

- + Good performance, Feature set; Light weight
- No in-built speakers

